

Employee Handbook — 2026 Updates

Effective May 26, 2026. Supplements the 2024 Employee Handbook. This document captures the cultural updates reinforced in Tuesday All-Hands meetings throughout 2026.

How to use this document: Read alongside the 2024 Employee Handbook. Where this document and the 2024 handbook differ, this 2026 update is authoritative. A full handbook refresh integrating these updates is planned for the next major revision.

1. The Five Operating Principles (NEW)

These five principles describe **how we work**. They are the operational expectations behind every Core Value. Memorize them — they are reinforced in every Tuesday All-Hands meeting.

01. Hand off the job so clean the next person never has to guess.

Do your job all the way to the finish line. The next person picking up your work shouldn't have to investigate, ask around, or guess what you did or why.

02. Adapt. Improve. Deliver.

Plans change. Customers change. The exact path to the outcome will shift. The outcome itself doesn't.

03. Own mistakes immediately.

Wrong thread color? Tell Ruthie now — before the customer ever sees it. Speed of acknowledgment matters more than perfection. We can fix what we know about; we can't fix what's hidden.

04. See the load. Share the load.

When you see a coworker drowning, you don't need permission to step in. When you're drowning, ask. Pretending everything is fine when it isn't hurts the team.

05. Silence breaks trust. Speak up.

If something's wrong, say so. If something could be better, say so. If you don't understand, say so. Silent disagreement and silent confusion both compound into bigger problems.

2. Core Values 2026 (replaces 2024 Core Values)

The 2024 Employee Handbook lists our Core Values as five abstract words. The 2026 version expands each with a **tagline** (what the value means) and the **sample phrases** staff actually say when living it. The phrases aren't scripts — they're the kinds of things you hear when the values are in motion.

Value	Tagline	Sample phrases staff actually say
Respect	We Lift Each Other Up.	"Help out." "We're in this together."
Excellence	We Figure It Out.	"We'll sort this out."
Accountability	We Own The Outcome.	"What can we take away from this?"
Compassion	We Protect Our People.	"Your well-being is important to us."

Honesty

We Close The Loop.

"I appreciate your honesty."

3. Vision 2026 (NEW)

Headline

People You Know. Quality You Trust.

The workplace we're building

A proactive and positive workplace that delivers WOW. A safe, high-trust environment where we shield each other from politics and communicate with the same kindness we show our best customers. This environment inspires creativity and WOW moments — a space where all ideas are welcomed and questions are always encouraged.

The heart of customer connection

People buy from people they know, like, and trust. Our showroom is where we make those connections happen. It is a welcoming space designed for us to become friends, and touch and feel the latest styles together. We focus on being nice and building the relationship first.

Strategic growth: trust is our currency

We are targeting **\$3.0M in 2026**, but we won't reach that goal by chasing transactions. **We play the long game.** We'll reach our goal by turning every visitor into a friend who knows, likes, and trusts us. When we focus on the relationship first, the sales follow naturally.

4. How These Three Fit Together

Vision	Where we're going. Trust is our currency. \$3M. People you know.
Core Values	What we stand for on the way. Respect, Excellence, Accountability, Compassion, Honesty — with concrete language.
Operating Principles	How we behave day-to-day. Clean handoffs, adapt & deliver, own mistakes fast, share the load, speak up.

You don't pick one. They're a stack. The Vision sets direction; the Values pick the route; the Principles drive the car.

5. What Still Applies from the 2024 Handbook

The 2024 Employee Handbook remains in effect for all sections not superseded by this document or by individual policies in the Policies Hub. That includes:

- Welcome letter, company history, mission statement, employment categories
- Code of Conduct, Diversity and Inclusion Policy, Workplace Bullying and Harassment Policy, Social Media Policy
- Work Conditions and Hours (with the Flex Time Policy 2026 layered on top for shifted/reduced arrangements)
- Leave and Time Off Policies (with Lunch Break, Vacation Scheduling, and Reinstatement & Rehire policies layered on top)

- Holiday Schedule, General Plant Rules, General Office Rules, Dress Code
- Health and Safety Policies (with Safety & Emergency Procedures policy layered on top)
- Payroll Information, Employee Suggestions Program, Referral Program, Employee Benefits
- Performance and Development, Annual Performance Reviews, Disciplinary Policies, Grievance Procedure, Termination of Employment

6. Where to Find Related Policies

These 2026 updates connect to several detailed policies in the Policies Hub at teamnwca.com/pages/policies-hub.html:

- **Operating Principles, Core Values & Vision 2026** — the live, editable version of this document
- **Flex Time Policy 2026** — schedule arrangements + tenure milestones + meeting attendance rules
- **Vacation Scheduling Policy 2026** — how to request, approve, and coordinate time off
- **Lunch Break Policy & Voluntary Meal Period Waiver** — WA labor law compliance + the meal waiver process
- **Reinstatement & Rehire Policy — 30-Day Window** — what carries over when a former employee comes back
- **Safety & Emergency Procedures** — fire, medical, evacuation, PPE, hazard reporting
- **Reprint & Defect Claim Policy** — NWCA-supplied garment defect handling
- **Customer-Supplied Garments — Misprint, Damage & Liability Policy** — customer-supplied garment handling, 3% allowance, intake process